

Model Council Synthesis: Why English Normandy Collapsed So Fast, 1449–1453

Council convened: Claude Fable 5, Claude Opus 5, Claude Sonnet 5.0, GPT-5.6 Sol, GPT-5.6 Terra, Gemini 3.1 Pro, Kimi K3, GLM 5.2 — each independently testing the author's pushback ("the speed of 1449–53 surely must come from artillery") against contemporary English and French sources. August 2026.

Where Models Agree

Finding	Claude Fable 5	Claude Opus 5	Claude Sonnet 5.0	GPT-5.6 Sol	GPT-5.6 Terra	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Kimi K3	GLM 5.2	Evidence
Contemporary English sources never blame French guns. The Suffolk impeachment, Cade's manifesto, <i>An English Chronicle</i> , Gregory's and Benet's chronicles, Gascoigne, and the Paston letters unanimously attribute the loss to treason (the Maine cession), unpaid and thinned garrisons, and royal insolvency	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	<i>An English Chronicle</i>; Cade's Complaint, Fordham Sourcebook; Paston Letters
The one English artillery mention inverts the thesis: Somerset's own 1449 dispatch to Parliament reported that Normandy had "no place... purveied nother in reparations, ordenaunce ne in eny maner artillerie" — an English procurement deficit, not a French wonder-weapon	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		✓		Anne Curry, "Was There a Military Revolution in Lancastrian Normandy?"
French sources credit the guns lavishly — but never alone. The <i>Recouvrement</i> tradition's own seven-part bilan names Norman consent, royal clemency, army discipline, numbers, Jacques Cœur's financing, and divine favor; artillery is not a standalone cause in the chroniclers' own accounting	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Contamine, "Un regard sur le Recouvrement de Normandie"; Blondel, <i>De Reductione Normanniae</i> (Stevenson ed.)
The mechanism of speed was anticipation, not battering. Most of the ~60–100 strongholds capitulated by negotiated composition without bombardment; artillery's causal work was to compress every commander's expected time-to-breach, making early surrender on generous terms rational	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Saint-Sauveur surrendered "sans cops de canons" with the train still packed at Bayeux (Stevenson); Curry: preparations, not bombardment, prompted surrender (Curry)
Relief probability was the master variable. Garrisons surrendered on relief-clause compositions ("unless relieved by a royal army by that day"); once Formigny (15 April 1450) destroyed the only English field force, every remaining clause was a foregone conclusion	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	Battle of Formigny, Britannica ; Worcester: Normans revolted through "wanhope, havynge no trust of hastie socoure" (Boke of Noblesse)

Finding	Claude Fable 5	Claude Opus 5	Claude Sonnet 5.0	GPT-5.6 Sol	GPT-5.6 Terra	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Kimi K3	GLM 5.2	Evidence
Truce-era demilitarization made Normandy structurally indefensible before a shot was fired: the Truce of Tours banned fortification repair and <i>appatis</i> , garrisons fell from ~3,500 to ~2,100–2,500, wages ran years into arrears, and the Maine cession discharged thousands more	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	<u>Curry</u> ; Worcester on "defaute of exercising of armes... thorough the said colour of trewes" (<u>Boke of Noblesse</u>)

Where Models Disagree

Topic	Claude Fable 5	Claude Opus 5	Claude Sonnet 5.0	GPT-5.6 Sol	GPT-5.6 Terra	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Kimi K3	GLM 5.2	Why
Is the author's "speed implies artillery" pushback vindicated?	Half right: artillery set the clock-speed of a collapse finance and politics made certain	No — the speed was contractual, not ballistic; the tempo belongs to the <i>délai de secours</i> , not the guns	Rejected: reforms and truce-era hollowing carry the weight; artillery was visible confirmation of a decided outcome	Substantially right on tempo, wrong if monocausal: "the ratchet's pawl and the campaign's clock"	Right to center speed; artillery was the conversion mechanism, not the autonomous cause	Entirely justified: artillery was an accelerant that "computationally solved the siege"	Partly vindicated — "speed is artillery's signature," and the winning side says so	A refinement, not a refutation: the speed came from a system, and contemporaries knew it	Differ thres what caus: a sur nego physi prod
When did the guns actually matter?	At the sieges actually fought: order-of-magnitude compression (Harfleur 17 days, Bayeux 16) vs. six-month starvation baselines	Phase split: Normandy's decisive fall (Jul–Nov 1449, incl. Rouen) happened with the guns almost invisible; bombardment does real work only in the winter/endgame sieges — crediting artillery for the collapse is a chronological inversion inside the campaign itself	Marginal throughout; even Caen fell to mining, and Verneuil's tower fell to hunger	Real at hard points (Harcourt, Argentan, Harfleur, Cherbourg), acting mostly through anticipated destruction	High tempo multiplier at selected places; medium general explanation	Throughout, as an unbluffable deterrent that made walls conceptually obsolete	Central and pervasive: Basin says Falaise, Domfront, Cherbourg fell "thanks above all to the power of the artillery"; one unauthorized demonstration shot at Caen produced an armistice	At four named sieges explicitly; the tempo itself was political-diplomatic (Blondel's <i>De Bello Insidiosio</i> framing)	Differ weigl Phas (whe duch fell) \ foughl (whe demc work
Castillon	The one clean case: a prepared artillery park destroying a field army	Skeptical — cites Michael Howard: "Castillon was in no sense a victory for field artillery"; Bureau's 1453 threat ended the war by testimony, not bombardment	Genuinely different in kind; the sole case where artillery is proximate and essential	Central but not solitary: guns organized the battlefield for an army (Breton arrival, sortie completed it)	The clean, bounded positive case — "only a state-capable organization makes cannon decisive at the required time and place"	(Not a focus)	Artillery-forward reading via d'Escouchy's "grant nombre d'artillerie" firing at full power	Basin blames Talbot's <i>temerity</i> and divine vengeance, not French technology	Whet privil tactic (gun-casu: Talbc or th conte mora (Engl
Best name for the mechanism of speed	Anticipation cascade	Contractual conquest — sixty legal instruments propagating one strategic fact	Hollowed occupation meeting funded force	Option removal: walls ceased to be time-generating political assets	Coercive bargaining inside a favorable political economy of surrender	Calculated certainty	The relief-clause institution made rational by the guns	Command paralysis: Somerset dared not take the field because he could not trust the towns (Basin/Escouchy)	Comj empl the le psycl politi operi faces same

Unique Discoveries

Model	Unique Finding	Why It Matters
Claude Opus 5	The <i>délai de secours</i> : nearly every place fell by notarized <i>appointement</i> fixing a surrender date "unless relieved" — sixty capitulations are one strategic fact propagated through sixty legal instruments; and the Phase One/Phase Two split showing the guns arrived after central Normandy had already gone	The sharpest structural rebuttal to "speed implies artillery" — the tempo was legal-contractual, and the chronological inversion recurs <i>inside</i> the campaign
Claude Opus 5	William Worcester's <i>Boke of Noblesse</i> — the nearest English staff analysis — whose Latin rubric states "lack of money to pay the soldiers was one cause of the betrayal of Normandy," and who prescribes copying French monthly pay (Gutenberg)	An English insider independently reinvents Blondel's <i>compagnies</i> analysis; the losing side's best analyst endorses the finance-first thesis
Claude Fable 5	The Gascony natural experiment: the same train won Guyenne by negotiation in 1451, lost it in a week in October 1452 over a broken tax exemption, and had to re-win it at Castillon — guns produce tempo, not allegiance	Cleanly separates what artillery can and cannot cause; directly usable as a controlled comparison in Chapter 6
Claude Sonnet 5.0	The 1452 Articles of Complaint of the Norman Estates — the province "depopulé et évacué," Valois taxes "importables," nearly as heavy as English ones	Norman "consent" in 1449–50 was a choice against a doomed occupier, not for the <i>taille</i> — a caution against romanticizing the popular-defection variable
GPT-5.6 Sol	Source-independence critique: the <i>Recouvrement</i> , Chartier, Berry Herald, and parts of d'Escouchy are one interdependent victory tradition, not four independent votes for artillery (Michaud-Fréjaville)	Deflates the apparent weight of French artillery testimony; a methodological point the book's Appendix should encode
GPT-5.6 Terra	Robert Bale's urban chronicle mentions ordnance only to lament the English <i>loss of their own gun stock</i> at Rouen; and Blondel's limiting case — one tower "could not be destroyed by any artillery stroke" and fell to hunger (Six Town Chronicles ; Stevenson)	Both sides' own texts falsify wall-obsolescence as a general law in 1450
Gemini 3.1 Pro	Thomas Basin negotiating Lisieux's surrender before a single shot was fired — the cleanest documented case of deterrence-by-reputation (Thomas Basin)	The purest illustration of artillery working entirely through expectation
Kimi K3	The unauthorized single demonstration shot at Caen that flattened a tower and immediately produced an armistice request; and Basin's coupled sentence — the last fortresses fell because relief hope "was utterly lacking" <i>and</i> they were hemmed in by "horrendous bombards"	The micro-mechanism of coercion-by-demonstration, and the fairest one-sentence contemporary verdict on the whole question
GLM 5.2	The Basin/d'Escouchy command-paralysis diagnosis: English captains "dared not assemble in the field nor leave their garrisons" because they could not trust the disaffected towns behind them — so no relief ever came and places fell "one after another" (Contamine/Cairn)	The contemporaries' own explanation of the domino tempo, and it is political, not technological

Comprehensive Analysis

The council's answer to the author's challenge is unusually decisive because it rests on a piece of evidence all eight models found independently and none expected to be so clean: **the contemporary English record is completely silent about French guns**. The Suffolk impeachment articles call the Maine cession the "chief cause of the loss of Normandy"; *An English Chronicle* blames Somerset, who "abatid the noubmre of the soudiers... and sente thaym in to Englond vnpaid of thair wages, wherby the strengthe of Normandie was lost"; Cade's rebels diagnose royal bankruptcy — "the kynge hym selffe is so set that he may not pay for his mete nor drynke"; Gregory, Benet, Gascoigne, and the Paston letters tell the same story of treason and insolvency ([An English Chronicle](#); [Fordham Sourcebook](#)). As Claude Fable 5 put it most sharply, this silence is evidentially strong precisely because the guns would have *exculpated* the men England was impeaching and lynching: an irresistible new French technology was the perfect excuse, and nobody used it. The one English text that names artillery at all — Somerset's own 1449 dispatch that Normandy had "no place... purveied nother in reparations, ordenaunce ne in eny maner artillerie" — describes an English procurement deficit, which six of the eight models flagged as the finding that turns the author's question inside out: 1449–50 was not guns versus walls but a funded artillery state versus an unfunded one ([Curry](#)).

On the French side, all eight models converged on a second structural fact: the victors credit the guns lavishly, but never alone, and never in their own summary accounting. The Berry Herald's superlative — no Christian king in living memory had such artillery — sits inside a bilan whose seven named causes are Norman willingness, campaign discipline, civilian protection, royal clemency, numbers, Jacques Cœur's financing ("rien de tout cela n'aurait été possible sans sire Jacques Cuer"), and God ([Contamine](#)). Monstrelet, the most artillery-forward contemporary, still concludes with "the grace of God chiefly, and also the skill and wisdom of his knights" ([Historical Association sourcebook](#)). And GPT-5.6 Sol added the methodological caution that the *Recouvrement*, Chartier, and Berry Herald are one interdependent victory tradition, not independent witnesses — so even the French artillery testimony counts for less than its volume suggests.

Yet the council did not simply re-affirm the prior verdict; it substantially upgraded the author's intuition about speed. All eight agree the thirteen months are real evidence of something artillery-shaped. Where the sieges were actually fought, compression was roughly an order of magnitude: Harfleur, which resisted Henry V for weeks in

1415, made terms after seventeen days under sixteen bombards; Bayeux fell in sixteen against six-month starvation baselines (Rogers). But the campaign's speed and the sieges' speed are different quantities. Most of the ~100 strongpoints on the contemporary English list were never besieged at all; Saint-Sauveur surrendered "without a shot, for the whole artillery remained packed at Bayeux" (Stevenson). The mechanism every model independently described — under different names: anticipation cascade, calculated certainty, option removal, coercive bargaining, the relief-clause institution — is that the guns changed what garrison commanders *expected*, and the expectation did the conquering. Claude Opus 5 gave this its most precise form: nearly every place fell by *appointment* with a *délai de secours*, a notarized date on which the gates would open unless a royal relief army appeared. Artillery priced the threat; Formigny deleted the relief; sixty legal clocks ran out.

The genuine disagreements are two, and both matter for Chapter 6. First, the phase question. Claude Opus 5 argues that Normandy's decisive fall — Rouen, the Seine, central Normandy — happened between July and November 1449 with the guns nearly invisible in the sources, bombardment doing its real work only in the winter sieges and the Cotentin endgame; on this reading, crediting artillery for the collapse repeats the book's original chronology error in miniature. Kimi K3 reads the same record the other way: Basin says the last fortresses fell "thanks above all to the power of the artillery," a single unauthorized shot at Caen produced an armistice, and speed is precisely artillery's signature. The resolution the evidence supports is that both are right about different halves of the campaign — which is itself the finding: the guns were decisive where and when they were present, and the duchy's center fell before they were. Second, Castillon. Five models keep it as the clean artillery case; GLM 5.2 notes Basin himself blames Talbot's temerity and divine vengeance, and Claude Opus 5 cites Michael Howard's flat dissent that Castillon "was in no sense a victory for field artillery." Even the book's cleanest exhibit, in other words, is contested in both the contemporary and modern literature and should be presented as such.

Claude Fable 5's Gascony natural experiment deserves separate emphasis because it isolates the variables the way no Norman evidence can: the same train took Guyenne by negotiation in 1451, lost it in a single week of October 1452 when Bordeaux invited Talbot back over a broken tax promise, and had to re-win it by fire in 1453. Guns generate tempo; they do not generate allegiance. Claude Sonnet 5.0's discovery of the Norman Estates' 1452 Articles of Complaint — the province "depopulé," Valois taxes nearly as heavy as English ones — makes the same point from inside the winning side: the consent that sped the reconquest was conditional and quickly soured.

Recommendation. The author's pushback should be absorbed, not resisted — but at a specified layer. The honest formulation, converged on in nearly identical words by five models, is Fable 5's: *artillery set the clock-speed of the collapse; finance and politics determined that a collapse would occur*. Chapter 6 should (1) split the tempo statistic explicitly — campaign speed (a capitulation cascade with political-fiscal causes) versus siege speed (genuinely ballistic, order-of-magnitude compression); (2) make the *délai de secours* composition the chapter's central device, since it is the documented legal mechanism through which expectation became territory; (3) quote Somerset's dispatch and Worcester's *Boke of Noblesse* as the English state's own finance-first post-mortem, and Blondel's epigram — "it is not walls that protect cities, but soldiers trained for war" — as the contemporary verdict on wall-obsolence; (4) present Castillon with Howard's dissent and Basin's temerity reading acknowledged; and (5) add the Gascony reversal as the controlled experiment separating tempo from allegiance. Framed this way, the thirteen months stop being a problem for the ratchet thesis and become its best demonstration: the artillery state's guns were the visible edge of a fiscal machine, and the speed of 1449–50 measured the gap between a polity that could pay for its walls and one that could not.